

A GLOBAL PERSPECTIVE We may be an ocean apart, but the people of the United States and France are similar in many ways. When a protest march was cancelled in Paris's Place de la Republique in 2015 due to concerns about terrorism, protestors placed thousands of pairs of shoes in the square as a silent yet effective expression of their protest and presence. How does this public protest compare to the Boston Tea Party?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s).
Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

2.3 The Boston Tea Party

Sit-ins, marches, posters, and chants are the tools of peaceful protest. They help people express displeasure or opposition without violence. The colonists were angry with the British, but sometimes they found ways to make their feelings known without lifting a weapon.

MAIN IDEA When Parliament imposed new laws to regulate tea, colonists responded by throwing a cargo of British tea into Boston Harbor.

NEW LAW, OLD TAX

At about the same time as the Boston Massacre, the British government decided to repeal most of the Townshend Acts. The taxes on all the items listed in the act were lifted, except for the tax on tea. There were fewer protests, and for two years, the relationship between Britain and the colonies was generally calm.

But in 1772, Patriots in Rhode Island burned a British ship that had been searching local boats for smugglers. When news of the attack reached England, Parliament once again began passing laws to gain greater control over the colonies. In Massachusetts, Samuel Adams responded by forming a **committee of correspondence**. This group made a list of British offenses against the colonies' rights and published it in Massachusetts. Other colonies joined in the movement by forming their own committees.

The committees soon had a new complaint. In 1773, Parliament passed the **Tea Act**, allowing the British East India Company to sell tea directly in the colonies. This lowered the price of tea, but it also took money away from colonial tea merchants. The prime minister also refused to repeal the Townshend Acts' tax on tea.

Despite the fact that cheaper tea would now be available, the new law fanned the flames of colonial resentment toward Britain. Colonial tea merchants were close to going out of business, and Parliament was still taxing the colonists without representation.

TEA OVERBOARD!

At first, the colonists protested by making it difficult for the British East India Company to deliver shipments of tea. Workers in major cities refused to unload shipments of tea from ships in port. In New York and Philadelphia, the ships' captains were told to return to England.

On the night of December 16, 1773, members of the Sons of Liberty disguised themselves as Native Americans and boarded three ships loaded with tea in Boston Harbor. Without harming the ships' other cargo, they dumped the tea into the icy water while thousands of people on shore watched the events of the **Boston Tea Party** unfold.

The Boston Tea Party was not the only act of colonial defiance that involved tea. On October 14, 1774, in Annapolis, Maryland, a ship with a cargo of tea was set on fire. King George was furious. Soon Parliament would enact new laws to punish the colonists for their actions, and the stage would be set for further conflicts.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** In what ways did the colonists protest the Tea Act?
2. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Was the Boston Tea Party an effective form of protest? Support your opinion with evidence from the text.
3. **MAKE GENERALIZATIONS** How did the Tea Act reflect the attitude of the British government toward the colonies?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.